7 The Iran–Iraq War 1980–8

POINTS TO CONSIDER
In 1980 Iraq invaded Iran, which led to one of the longest and most destructive wars of the twentieth century. To understand the background to, and reasons for, this war, the Iraq of Saddam Hussein and the Iranian Revolution of 1979 are first examined, then the war itself and its impact are assessed under the headings of:

- Iraq and the rise of Saddam Hussein
- The Iranian Revolution 1979
- The Iran–Iraq War 1980–8

Key dates

1919	British granted a mandate over Iraq
1953	Overthrow of Mossadeq's government in Iran
1958	Iraqi army overthrew the monarchy
1968	Baathists seized power in Iraq
1979	Saddam Hussein became President of Iraq
	Iranian Revolution led by Ayatollah Khomeini
1980–8	Iran–Iraq War

1 | Iraq and the Rise of Saddam Hussein

Iraq lies in the ancient land of Mesopotamia, one of the world's oldest civilisations. The first cities were built here, the most famous of which was Baghdad. The Hanging Gardens of Babylon, built over 2000 years ago, became one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World. Many centuries later, in the seventh century AD, the land of Iraq was invaded by the Arabs and its people adopted both the language, Arabic, and the religion, Islam, of the invaders. Then, from the sixteenth century, Iraq was ruled by the Ottoman Turks.

Key question
Why was Iraq important to the British?

Iraq in the First World War

At the beginning of the twentieth century the British, as well as other European countries, were keen to gain a foothold in Iraq. The main reason was oil. Oil had been discovered in the south of Iran, near the Iraqi border, and was likely to be present in Iraq. At this time, Britain's navy, the largest in the world, was